

September 9, 2026

To Whom It May Concern:

This letter is to confirm that Santo Kabir Ahmed successfully participated in the Freshwater and Community Conservation Externship, an eight-week professional learning experience offered by Extern in collaboration with the National Geographic Society and The Nature Conservancy, from July 14 to September 8, 2025.

The externship is designed to help young people build their freshwater conservation knowledge, strengthen community awareness and engagement, develop career-readiness skills, and connect with conservation professionals from the National Geographic Society and The Nature Conservancy. Throughout the eight-week program, Santo participated in a combination of asynchronous learning, live program meetings, guest speaker sessions, and mentorship opportunities with conservation professionals and peers from around the world. Mentor sessions provided opportunities for externs to receive guidance on topics including research, solution development, career development, and environmental storytelling.

As part of the externship, Santo investigated a freshwater conservation challenge within a local context. The project experience guided externs through learning the fundamentals of freshwater conservation, conducting primary and secondary research into local conservation challenges and existing efforts, completing a landscape and gap analysis, and developing potential solutions. Externs then learned to communicate their research and proposed community action through an ArcGIS StoryMap. Santo successfully completed the program requirements and received a \$500 USD stipend.

Following the externship, Santo was selected as one of 14 externs to receive \$2,000 USD in Seed Funding to put his learning into action through a community-based conservation project. He received the grant in November 2025 and carried out his project, "Dhaleshwari River Pollution Awareness," over a six-month period.

Santo's project focused on raising community awareness of tannery pollution in Bangladesh's Dhaleshwari River following the relocation of the tannery industry. Over the course of the project, he assembled and worked with a 20-member volunteer team and led four community events and awareness campaigns, including educational programming in local schools and student art competitions.

The Seed Funding experience also included continued guidance from the Extern team throughout the six-month implementation period. Santo participated in three structured check-ins, held every other month, where he had the opportunity to discuss his project's progress, challenges, and next steps. These sessions provided guidance to seed funding recipients as they moved from their initial project plans into implementation, including support around tracking and reporting project impact and reflecting on outcomes and learnings.

Through both the eight-week externship and subsequent six-month Seed Funding experience, Santo demonstrated his commitment to translating conservation learning into tangible action within his community. His progression from researching freshwater conservation challenges during the externship to implementing his own locally focused awareness initiative reflects the broader goal of the program: empowering young people to apply conservation knowledge and create meaningful impact in their communities.

We are pleased to confirm Santo's successful participation and accomplishments through the Freshwater and Community Conservation Externship and Seed Funding programs.

Sincerely,

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